Cheras

Muvendars (Three Great Kings) controlled the territories of Tamizhagam during the Sangam Age. The Tamil word 'Vendar' was used to refer to three dynasties, namely the Cheras, Cholas and Pandyas. The Cheras ruled over the central and north Travancore, Cochin, south Malabar and Kongu region of Tamil Nadu. The *Pathitrupathu* (a collection of ten decades of verses) provides information about the Chera kings. It is known that the Chera king Senguttuvan went on a military expedition to North India. He brought stones from the Himalayas for making the idol of Kannagi, an epic character from *Silappathikaram*. He introduced *pattini* cult. Cheran Senguttuvan's younger brother was Ilango Adigal. He was the author of *Silappathikaram*. Another Chera king, Cheral Irumporai, issued coins in his name. Some Chera coins bear their emblem of bow and arrow.

Prominent Chera Rulers

- Udayan Cheralathan
- Imayavaramban Netun Cheralathan
- Cheran Senguttuvan
- Cheral Irumporai

Cholas

The Chola kingdom of Sangam period extended upto Venkatam (Tirupathi) hills. The Kaveri delta region remained the central part of the kingdom. This area was later known as Cholamandalam. KarikalValavan or Karikalan was the most famous of the Chola kings. He defeated the combined army of the Cheras, Pandyas and the eleven Velir chieftains who supported them at Venni, a small village in the Thanjavur region.

He converted forests into cultivable lands. He built Kallanai (meaning a dam made of stone) across the river Kaveri to develop agriculture. Their port Puhar attracted merchants from various regions of the Indian Ocean. The *Pattinapaalai*, a poetic work in the *Pathinenkeezhkanakku*, gives elaborate information of the trading activity during the rule of Karikalan.

Kallanai

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It was a dyke, built with stones. It was constructed across the Kaveri to divert water throughout the delta region for irrigation. When it was built, Kallanai irrigated an area of about 69,000 acres.



Prominent Chola Rulers

- Ilanchetsenni
- KarikalValavan
- Kocengannan
- KilliValavan
- Perunarkilli

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